From a single piece of seafood to a simple swirl of cream, a well-chosen garnish transforms a soup, adding extra color, as well as texture and flavor.

garnishing

For some soups, a garnish is an essential component—the sour cream stirred into Borscht, for instance, or the cheese-topped croûtes served with French onion soup. For others, a garnish is a way of introducing contrasting textures and flavors. Many ingredients can act as a garnish if they also complement the flavors of the soup, but here is a selection to suit almost every type.

with cream



Dolloped, swirled, or drizzled, cream makes an excellent garnish for thick puréed soups. Use heavy cream, whipped cream, sour cream, or crème fraîche. Yogurt is also a good alternative if you're counting calories.

with herbs



Fresh sage or parsley leaves fried in olive oil until crisp make a flavorful garnish for gutsy soups, but a sprinkling of chopped parsley, chervil, or cilantro instantly adds interest, fragrance, and color to almost any soup.